how to get clients for your ai agency

once you dial in your angles and hit 2%+ response rate, 10+ calls/week is standard

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why cold pitching is dead in 2025

every ceo, founder, and business owner is drowning in cold pitches

their inbox looks like this:

- "quick question about [company]"
- "saw you on linkedin, let's hop on a call"
- "we help companies like yours with [generic benefit]"
- "15 minutes to discuss how we can 10x your revenue"

they get 50+ of these per day

all asking for their time, attention, and money without giving anything in return

the result?

- delete
- delete
- delete

unless you have massive case studies (like "we worked with alex hormozi" level), direct pitches don't work anymore

you're competing with hundreds of other agencies saying the exact same thing

the trust barrier is too high

people don't trust cold pitches from strangers

they need a reason to believe you're worth their time

and "let's hop on a quick call" isn't a good enough reason

the problem with your current approach

you're cold pitching $5k contracts to people who've never heard of you

that's like proposing marriage on a first date

nobody's signing that contract

you're skipping the "coffee date" part and going straight to asking them to move in with you

here's what actually happens:

- you send: "we can help you scale with ai video ads"
- they think: "who tf is this person and why should i care"
- they ghost you

sound familiar?

the solution: the podcast method

instead of begging for meetings, you make them want to talk to you

here's the core idea:

you invite them to be featured on your "podcast"

(it's not a real podcast - it's just a recorded call where you ask them about their business and expertise)

here's how it works:

step 1: invite them to your "podcast"

- you reach out saying you're featuring leaders in their industry
- the topic is something they care about and want to discuss
- you position them as an expert worth interviewing

step 2: give value upfront

- they get a platform to share their insights
- they feel noticed, respected, and important
- you build trust without pitching anything
- it's just a conversation about their work

step 3: transition naturally

- during the call, you learn about their challenges
- after the podcast, you discuss how you might help
- if there's a fit, you move to a real sales call
- if not, you still built a relationship

the psychology: why this actually works

humans are driven by two core things: **reputation** and **identity**

reputation:

- everyone wants to be seen as an expert
- being "featured" makes them feel recognized
- it validates their work and achievements
- they get positive visibility without paying for it

identity:

- they feel unique and special (not just another email in their inbox)
- being interviewed positions them as a thought leader
- they're part of something important
- it strokes their ego in a good way

the beauty of this method:

1. **no pressure** - it's collaborative, not transactional
2. **curiosity** - they want to know more about you and your platform
3. **reciprocity** - you gave them value first, so they're more likely to give back
4. **natural transition** - after the call, selling feels effortless

you're not asking them to marry you on the first date

you're asking them to grab coffee and chat

way easier to say yes to

why the podcast doesn't need to be "real"

when people hear "podcast," they think:

- professional studio setup
- published on spotify/apple
- big production value

forget all that

your "podcast" is just:

- a recorded zoom call
- you asking them questions about their business
- 20-30 minutes of conversation

that's it

you can grow it into something bigger later if you want

but right now, it's just a positioning play to get them on calls

if they ask to see previous episodes:

- "we're just kicking this off, and i'd love for you to be one of our first conversations"
- or record one fake episode with a friend and upload to youtube

most people won't even ask

they just say yes because it makes them feel good

the long game

not every prospect will become a client immediately

some will just do the podcast and move on

that's okay

because:

- you built a real relationship
- they'll remember the positive experience
- you stay top of mind for future opportunities
- they might refer you to someone else

the people where there's real alignment?

they naturally move to the next "date" - a follow-up call to explore working together

no hard pitch needed

bottom line: stop selling, start building relationships

direct pitches = asking strangers to trust you with $5k

podcast invites = asking them to chat about something they love

one feels desperate

the other feels like an opportunity

which one do you think gets more yeses?

part 1: setup (domains & inboxes)

you need multiple email inboxes to send cold emails at scale without burning your main domain

buy 1 main domain

go to porkbun.com

- search for your business name
- stick to .com
- buy for 1 year only

set up google workspace

go to google workspace pricing

- select business standard
- enter business details
- create primary account username
- verify domain with TXT record in porkbun DNS

buy domains & inboxes on instantly.ai

sign up:

- go to instantly.ai
- create account (use email + password, not google login)
- verify email

buy domains:

- select "done-for-you email setup"
- choose "new domains"
- type your main domain keyword
- select 6 domains (.com, .co, .org)
- add your main domain as "forwarding domain"
- set email to "all domains" (creates 3 inboxes per domain = 18 total)
- pay (monthly fee per inbox + annual fee for domains)

wait 24-72 hours for setup

part 2: warmup (2 weeks)

warmup = sending fake emails between inboxes so email providers trust you

configure settings:

1. go to email accounts in instantly
2. select all 18 inboxes (checkbox in header)
3. click settings icon → bulk edit settings
4. fill out:
    - sender name: your first + last name
    - signature: name, job title, company, address
    - daily campaign limit: 35

    - increase per day: 2
    - daily warmup limit: 35
    - reply rate: 100%
5. save

monitor:

- takes ~3 days for setup to complete
- wait 2 weeks before sending real emails
- always keep warmup running (even during campaigns)

upgrade to hypergrowth before warmup starts so it doesn't get interrupted

part 3: scrape leads

use apollo.io

sign up:

- go to apollo.io
- create free account
- verify email

create search:

filters to use:

- **email status**: verified + likely to send (exclude unverified)
- **job titles**: ceo, founder, co-founder, owner, president
- **location**: united states (or your target country)
- **# employees**: 1-100
- **industry**: search your niche (e.g., "marketing & advertising" or "computer software")

save your search link

scrape leads

- go to Apollo
- click "scrape leads now"
- fill out form:
    - full name
    - email
    - paste apollo search link
    - select # of leads (match your apollo search count)
    - choose country
- submit payment
- wait 24-72 hours for csv file via email

part 4: verify emails

why this matters: if you send to bad emails, your domains get burned and land in spam

use millionverifier:

1. go to millionverifier.com
2. create account
3. buy credits (match # of leads in your list)
4. upload your csv file
5. wait for verification (may take hours)
6. download "good emails only"
7. import to google sheets

filter for good emails:

- file → import → upload millionverifier report
- select "quality" column
- data → create filter
- filter for "good" only

now you have clean, deliverable emails

part 5: write scripts with ai

use chatgpt to generate emails

get the template:

- template: [link to google doc]
- prompt: [link to google doc]

customize the prompt:

1. copy prompt into chatgpt (gpt-4o with web browsing)
2. replace [niche] with your target industry
3. hit enter

chatgpt will:

- research pain points in your niche
- generate 10 headline variations
- output 10 complete email scripts using the podcast method template

copy emails and tweak:

- personalize with your info
- adjust tone if needed
- keep it under 100 words

part 6: set up campaign in instantly

prepare lead spreadsheet

1. open your verified leads sheet
2. create new sheets: "batch #1", "batch #2", etc
3. copy header row to each batch
4. split leads into batches of 2,500
5. download batch #1 as csv

create campaign

name it:

- format: "podcast method - [industry] [size] - [location] - [titles]"
- example: "podcast method - software companies 1-100 - us - ceos founders"

import leads:

1. go to campaigns → add new
2. click leads tab → add leads → upload csv
3. map fields:
    - first name, last name, email
    - custom variables: title, employees, industry, company linkedin, etc
4. upload all

set up sequences:

step 1:

- subject: "quick question"
- body: paste your email script from chatgpt
- replace placeholders with variables: `[[first_name]]`, `[[industry]]`, etc
- add 9 more variants (10 total)

step 2 (follow-up after 3 days):

- subject: leave blank (uses step 1 subject)

body:
hey [[first_name]]just following up on my invitation from earlier. let me know if this is something you'd be interested in.[[account_signature]]

-

schedule:

- verify timing: 9am-6pm eastern, monday-friday

options:

- accounts to use: select all 18 inboxes
- stop sending on reply: enabled
- open tracking: disabled
- delivery optimization: disabled
- daily limit: 630 (35 per inbox × 18)
- time gap: 13 minutes
- max new leads: 315 (50% of daily limit)
- prioritize new leads: enabled
- auto optimize a/b testing: disabled

save and launch (only if inboxes are warmed up)

part 7: manage responses

use instantly unibox

what it is:

- unified inbox for all 18 email accounts
- see all responses in one place

filter by status:

- unread
- positive replies
- neutral
- negative

reply fast:

- aim for 15 mins - 3 hours max
- every minute you wait = lower chance of booking

set reminders:

- check "if no reply" when sending
- choose date for follow-up
- unibox will remind you

part 8: handle common responses

"can you send more info?"

option 1:

absolutely. what information would you need to determine if this could be a fit for {company}?

if you have a couple minutes on thursday or friday, i can share more detail over a quick call - just let me know.

option 2:

absolutely. here's a quick video outlining what we're doing:

[+ video link]

would you have time on [date] or [date] for a quick chat?

"sounds good, let's discuss"

great! how does 10am or 11am on tuesday sound?

"no thanks"

thanks for letting me know - no problem at all!

quick question: do you know anyone in [industry] who might find value in partnering with us?

p.s. we offer a referral commission for any introductions that result in a collaboration

"send me an example episode"

if you don't have one yet:

hi {firstname},

we're just starting to feature companies in {industry}, and i'd love for {company} to be among the first.

i'd be happy to share our vision on a quick call. let me know if thursday or friday works!

"i never gave permission to be contacted"

hi {firstname},

your email was obtained through a third-party software as according to GDPR policy.

happy to point you in the direction of the software if you want to take this up with them.

let me know if you want to opt-out and we'll remove you from the database.

part 9: book calls with calendly

set up calendly

1. go to calendly.com
2. connect your google calendar
3. connect zoom
4. create event types:
    - podcast call (30 mins)
    - growth plan presentation (60 mins)
5. set up reminders:
    - 24 hours before
    - 1 hour before
    - 15 mins before

book manually first:

- offer 2 specific dates within 5 days
- example: "does tuesday at 10am or wednesday at 2pm work?"
- only send calendly link after they agree to a time

part 10: track performance

the 250 rule

wait until you've contacted **250 leads per variant** before making decisions

calculate positive response rate

formula:

(positive responses ÷ contacted leads) × 100

target: 2% positive response rate

if below 2%

- create 10 new variants with different headlines
- send to another 250 leads per variant
- keep testing (15-25 headlines is normal)

if you hit 2%+

- turn off all other variants
- add more leads to the winner
- create 5-10 new variations based on winning angle

if nothing works after 30-40 variants

- review your targeting
- try cold calling as backup
- consider pivoting to different niche

part 11: scale

when to add more leads

once you're getting consistent replies and hitting 2%+ response rate

where to find more leads

option 1: expand apollo filters

- increase company size (1-200 employees)
- add more job titles (vp, director, head of [dept])
- test sub-niches before new industries

option 2: use linkedin sales navigator

- recreate your apollo search
- extract with scraping tool
- upload to apollo to enrich

option 3: verify "catch-all" emails

- export unknown/catch-all from apollo
- upload to scrubby.io
- keep emails with 75%+ deliverability

recycle old leads (90+ days later)

when to use:

- you're out of fresh leads
- testing new angles
- waiting for next scrape

how to do it:

1. go to old campaign in instantly
2. filter: status = "not contacted" or replied = no
3. export as csv
4. create new campaign with different copy
5. upload and launch

golden rules

do:

- respond within 15 mins - 3 hours
- be direct and conversational
- follow up every 48 hours
- book calls manually first
- test 15-25+ headlines

don't:

- use "hope you're well" or fluff
- send calendly links first
- give up after 1-2 follow-ups
- share pricing before the call
- use same email script twice

bottom line

the podcast method works because you're giving value before asking for anything

you're not cold pitching huge contracts

you're inviting them to share their expertise

people say yes because it makes them feel important

then you transition naturally into how you can help

that's it

now go book some calls

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